

CORE FORMULA

Listen for an endorsed value -> name it tentatively -> connect it to the choice -> leave autonomy intact. -> Given how much you care about fairness, the process might matter as much as the outcome. -> You have said quality matters more than speed here - does that change the decision? -> If protecting trust is the value, the next step probably needs to be visible. -> Because autonomy matters to you, I would frame this as a choice rather than an instruction.

MINIMUM VIABLE MOVE

Name one value the person has actually stated, link it to the choice in a single plain sentence, and leave the decision with them.

BEST FOR

- Framing a decision so it fits what the person already cares about
- Motivating action when facts alone are not enough
- Clarifying trade-offs between competing priorities
- Making a request feel consistent rather than imposed
- Leadership conversations about why a choice matters
- Helping someone see their own values in a hard call

PHRASE BANK

Quick starters · Short openers

- "You care about getting this right - does that point one way?"
- "Sounds like fairness matters most here."
- "If reliability is the priority, one option fits better."
- "That reads like a trust question to me."
- "Feels like this comes down to what you value most."
- "You have said quality matters - does that settle it?"
- "Given what matters to you, which way feels more like you?"
- "Is this really about speed, or about doing it properly?"

Warm / tentative naming · Naming the value gently

- "The thing I keep hearing you value is fairness - am I reading that right?"
- "It sounds like being honest with them matters to you a lot."
- "You seem to care most about not letting people down."
- "I might be wrong, but loyalty seems to be doing a lot of the work here."
- "What I am picking up is that you would rather be straight than smooth."
- "It feels like protecting the relationship matters more than winning the point."
- "You have mentioned trust a few times - it clearly means something to you."

Work / decisions · Meeting, client, decision

- "You have framed reliability as the priority - option B looks more consistent with that."
- "If quality matters more than speed here, the timeline might need to move."
- "Given the team values transparency, showing the reasoning may matter as much as the decision."
- "You said the client relationship comes first - does that change which we choose?"
- "If protecting trust is the goal, the next step probably needs to be visible."
- "Since fairness is the standard we have set, the process should probably match it."

- "You have been clear that developing people matters - this call could reflect that."

Framing the ask · Requests, trade-offs

- "Because autonomy matters to you, I would put this as a choice, not an instruction."
- "You care about doing it once and doing it well - can we build in the extra day?"
- "Given how much fairness matters to you, would you be open to hearing both sides first?"
- "If consistency is what you value, could we apply the same rule here?"
- "You have said clarity matters - can I check I have understood before I ask?"
- "Since you value people's time, shall we keep this to one decision?"

Softening / stepping back · Releasing the pressure

- "I may have read your values wrong there - put me straight."
- "Let me say that more plainly, without the frame."
- "I do not want to put words in your mouth about what matters to you."
- "Forget how I framed it - what actually matters to you here?"
- "No need to make this about principles if it is not helpful."
- "I jumped ahead by naming a value you had not. My mistake."
- "That came out more loaded than I meant - let me try again."

Conflict / pressure · Contested or guarded

- "I am not telling you what to value - I am checking whether this fits what you already do."
- "You care about fairness, and so do I - can we start from there?"
- "If we both value getting this right, the disagreement is about how, not whether."
- "I know trust matters to you here, which is exactly why I want to be careful with it."
- "This is your call. I am only pointing out where it lines up with what you have said matters."
- "If I have misjudged what is important to you, tell me and I will drop it."

Digital / text · One clean line

- "To make sure I am framing this right - is trust the thing that matters most here?"
- "Quick check: is this a fairness question or a speed question for you?"
- "Before I reply properly - which value should this decision protect?"
- "Useful if I name what I think matters to you, or would that overstep?"
- "One line: does this fit what you said you cared about, or not quite?"

WEAK -> BETTER -> BEST

1. Weak: If you were a good leader, you would do this.

Better: You have said trust matters here, so a visible follow-up may matter.

Best: Given that trust has been your stated priority, the strongest move may be the one that shows the team how the decision was made, not just what it is.

2. Weak: Just pick the fast option, obviously.

Better: You care about quality, so the quick option might cost you later.

Best: You have said quality matters more than speed here - does the fast option actually serve that, or just feel like progress?

3. Weak: Be fair and say yes.

Better: You value fairness, so it might be worth hearing them out first.

Best: Since fairness is something you hold to, would it feel right to hear both sides before you decide?

DECISION TREE

If The person is still speaking

Hold the frame; do not interrupt to name a value.

If You are not sure what they value

Check tentatively before you frame anything.

"What matters most to you in this one?"

If They are resisting

Validate the concern before you offer a frame.

"That is fair - what feels off about it?"

If You have not earned the value yet

Ask, do not assert; let them name it.

"Would you say fairness is the priority here, or something else?"

If The frame increased ease

Continue, and connect it to the next step.

"If that is the value, the next step might be to make it visible."

If The frame reduced ease

Repair or release straight away.

"I may have read that wrong - let me put it more simply."

SCENARIOS

Social conversation

Keep it warm and brief; name the value lightly and let them run with it. — "Sounds like doing right by your mates matters more than being liked here."

Professional discussion

Name the action or concern clearly and tie the value to the decision at hand. — "You have said reliability comes first - option B is the more consistent one with that."

Digital message

Write one clean sentence; do not overexplain or stack the frame with reasons. — "Quick check - is this a fairness call or a speed call for you?"

Conflict or objection

Validate or summarise the concern before you offer any values frame. — "I get why that lands badly. We both want this to be fair - can we start there?"

High-status or guarded person

Make the move optional and low-pressure; offer the value as a question, not a claim. — "If I have got what matters to you wrong, say so and I will drop it."

Close relationship

Avoid sounding like a technique; use ordinary language and no polished framing. — "You have always cared about being straight with people - does waiting sit right with you?"

WHEN NOT TO USE

- You do not actually know their values
- The value is sensitive, contested or still raw
- Urgency requires direct action, not framing
- The frame would shame, corner or expose them
- You would be lending them a value for your own convenience
- Physical safety or an emergency takes priority

7-DAY PRACTICE DRILL

Day 1 — Spot the value

In three conversations today, notice one value each person actually states or shows. Write each one down. Frame nothing yet - just catch the cue.

Day 2 — Name it tentatively

Take yesterday's cues and write a one-line tentative naming for each: "It sounds like X matters to you." No decision attached, no verdict.

Day 3 — Connect to a choice

Take five real conversations from last week. For each, write the cue you missed and the one-sentence values-frame you could have used.

Day 4 — Add the autonomy tail

Rewrite each of yesterday's lines so it ends by leaving the decision with them - "...but it is your call" or "...does that fit, or not quite?"

Day 5 — Say it plainly

Read each line aloud until it stops sounding scripted. Cut anything that sounds like a buzzword or a moral lecture.

Day 6 — Practise the repair

Deliberately over-frame one line so it lends a value, then practise a recovery line that names the miss and releases the pressure.

Day 7 — Live field test

Use the move once in a real conversation. Watch the calibration cue and note whether it increased or reduced ease.

AFTER-ACTION CHECKLIST

- Did I name a value the person actually owns, not one I lent them?
- Did I keep the move short and plain?
- Did I leave the decision with them?
- Did I check rather than assume what mattered?
- Did I watch their response instead of pushing on?
- Did I repair quickly when it missed?